III

I received numerous invitations to speak, the majority of which I turned down. But I could not turn down every request, and gave a speech on average once a month – later I realized this was not different from the frequency with which the Fed Chairman spoke in public. In India, however, the 24x7 channels, hungry for news, ensured that no speech went uncovered, no matter how minor the occasion or remote the location. Given press presence, I could not repeat speeches (the less there was a new message to report, the more likely the press might 'make' news by latching on to something peripheral), nor could I speak on monetary policy or financial sector reforms in every speech. What better way to speak on something different than to go back to my research on the political economy of reforms and growth, especially if it could contribute to the public debate as well as the RBI's mission? In the Lalit Doshi Memorial Lecture in August 2014, I linked the environment we lived in in India to the need for furthering our efforts on financial inclusion.

Finance and Opportunity in India

We are approaching the 67th anniversary of our Independence. Sixty-seven years is a long time in the life of man – indeed, it is about the average Indian's life expectancy today. Since life expectancy was shorter at the time of Independence, it is safe to say that most Indians born just after Independence are now no more. It is useful to take stock at such a time. Did we achieve the dreams of our founding fathers for freedom's first children? Or have we fallen woefully short? What more do we need to do?

Clearly, our founding fathers wanted political freedom for the people of India – freedom to determine who we would be governed by, as well as freedom of thought, expression, belief, faith, and worship. They wanted justice and equality, of status and opportunity. And they wanted us to be free from poverty.